

CRESCENT- SHOUSETOWN AREA HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

P.O. BOX 253, Crescent, PA 15046

July 2012

2012-1

LETS REINVIGORATE THE ASSOCIATION

by Don Harper, Editor

Welcome to the first edition of the resurrected newsletter. It has been many years since the last edition and we believe it is time to bring it back to keep members connected and give them a reason to belong to the organization.

We are starting off small. This is a two-pager. As membership grows we hope to expand the newsletter to several pages devoted to the history of Crescent Township and its inhabitants and, we hope, will include stories of the old times as written down by our ancestors, or recollected by their descendants.

For anyone unfamiliar with the Association, the Crescent-Shousetown Area Historical Association was formed in 1981 with twenty members, all local residents. Membership grew and attracted members from as far away as Oregon and Texas.

Meetings are held at the Crescent Township Municipal building quarterly, on the second Wednesday of March, June and September. The December meeting, which was an annual Christmas dinner, has been discontinued for the time being. Membership is open to anyone interested in the history of the area and preserving it. If interested in becoming a member, contact Helen Mitchell, 724-457-7630, and request an application. Visitors are always welcome at meetings.

The Association has accomplished a great deal during its 31-year existence. For example, it:

- ° Created a collection of printed materials, photographs, and articles detailing life over the years in the Township. These materials are located in a room in the Municipal Building's meeting room. The items are available for inspection, providing a member of the Association is on hand to open the room and supervise the inspection. Some of these items help to identify historic sites in the "Landmarks Locator" found at the front of the Municipal Building.
- ° Placed and dedicated, in 1988, a historical marker "Place of Beginning", signifying the start and end of the original Allegheny County Survey. This marker is located at the corner of Front and Ferry Streets in the old Shousetown section of Crescent.

- ° Recognized the historic value of the Shouse House with a plaque from the Association and the Pittsburgh History and Landmarks Association. The plaque, unfortunately, did not prevent this historic house from being demolished by the individual who purchased it, and the plot of land now sits empty.
- ° Installed the "Great Republic" Steamboat granite monument and time capsule. This monument is located at the intersection of Riverview Road and McGovern Boulevard.

My roots run deep in Crescent Township. Although I have never lived in Crescent, my grandfather, Frank E. Harper, was born there and lived there as boy. My great-grandfather, Joseph W. Harper, owned an L-shaped home-store at the corner of Front and Ferry Streets. His wife's parents, the Scharpfs, owned a home and boot makers shop where the Municipal Building and Fire Hall now stand. Prior to the home-store, Great Grandpa Joseph owned a home up on the bluff where Shouse Park now stands. My great-great grandfather, William T. Harper, lived up on top of the hill above McGovern Boulevard and was responsible for getting Harper Road installed. Before Harper Road, the family had to travel up a very steep dirt road that cut off Bocktown Road; some portions of this old road are still visible in the fall. Plus he donated the land for the former Riverdale Church on McGovern Boulevard. And my great-great-great grandfather David Harper purchased, in 1825, the plot of land where Harper Village now sits.

My grandfather regularly brought my brothers and me to Shousetown to play on the small delta at "The Point" where Flaugherty Run empties into the Ohio River (at least until the site was messed up when the airport was being constructed and construction material were unloaded there). And he told us tales of living there as a boy before the family packed up in 1892 and moved to Coraopolis, where his father constructed a nearly-identical home-store on the corner of Fourth and Montour that still stands.

Grandpa Harper left us an extensive written record of his early life in Shousetown. In this inaugural issue,

I'm going to share some of his memories in hopes of stimulating more of the same from long-time residents of Crescent whose parents or grandparents may have written down some of their memories.

Grandpa wrote:

"If you have a doubt in your mind as to my age and ability to row a boat, just remember that this was Shousetown, and that long before I left there at nine, we boys helped Mr. Keim with the ferry, and many, many, times when we were taking over a horse and wagon in the big flat bottomed boat and a foot passenger appeared on either shore, we would loosen the skiff, row to the shore and deliver the passenger to the other side. Nicknames such as 'Fish' and 'River Rat' went with me through a good part of my life and mother used to plague me by saying I was not really her boy, that they caught me coming down the river in a bath tub. This never seemed much of a stretch of the imagination to me, for I saw the Johnstown flood, which was in 1889, and consequently I was just six years old. There were things come down the river that was just as strange as a baby in a bath tub. For one day our house, part of the back yard, and a little stretch of road in front of the store were

an island. All day long men would row up the street, pull their boat across this narrow neck of dry land, launch it on the other side and by hugging the shore make their way up the river to Dead Man Island. All day long a seemingly endless raft of smashed houses, furniture, branches and whole trees, logs, bodies, and all the terror that had once been Johnstown, went floating by. Just below the island the boats would shoot out and be hauled up on this debris while the occupants salvaged whatever took their fancy. Just about where the boat yards had been they would put off from the raft, row to shore, unload their prizes, and start back on the next trip.

We had at least one piece of furniture in our house for years that was secured in that manner. Does this sound heartless? If so remind yourself again that this was Shousetown. Most of the firewood, quite a bit of the lumber, and a large percentage of the coal used was salvaged from the river. Believe it or not, all of the fish we ate came from the same place. People were not rich nor even well to do, but when the distress call came from that stricken city, a box car full of clothes and food was soon on the way."



This photo, made in 1886, shows Great-grandpa Joseph Harper's store and home at the corner of Front and Ferry Streets in Shousetown. Joseph is standing in the doorway. Grandpa Harper is the small child seated on the windowsill of the lower left window. This store-home was sold to one of the Wynns when the Harpers moved to Coraopolis. It subsequently burned and the plot of land sat vacant for years before a smaller home was constructed there.

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October 2012

2012-2

THE SEPTEMBER MEETING

by Don Harper, Editor

During the September 12th quarterly meeting of the Association, several things were accomplished. First, the members voted to reinstate the dues structure (\$6.00 for an individual, \$10.00 for a family per year) beginning in January 2013. These funds will be used to offset the costs of printing the newsletter. Second, the members voted to reinstate the winter meeting.

Much of the discussion revolved around generating interest in the Association via presentations at the meetings, and outreach to the community that would result in positive publicity for the Association. Helen Mitchell handed out a sheet jam packed with ideas. Among them were the following:

- Develop an index of newsletter subjects.
- Gather the history of Association past events, memorials, published booklets, etc. and assemble them into a booklet.
- Invite people to research Crescent Township history for possible newsletter articles or meeting presentations.
- Possible topics include:
 - Dashields Dam history
 - Premier Pan
 - Bosetti Hardware
 - Shafer Bus Line
 - Shouse Park
 - Glenwillard School
 - Churches

P&LE station
Fire Department
Boatbuilding
K.C. Jackson Abrasives
Ferries
Old Township maps
Major land owners
Old County roads
Water and sewer authority
Eberle family
Old cemeteries
Old farms/estates/homes/buildings
Railroad to Frankfort Springs
Oil and gas wells
Rooney Bar in Wireton
Famous residents
Riverfront businesses
Development of McGovern Boulevard
Relocation of Flaugherty Run

- Research old land grants, property histories, etc.
- Locate and identify old photographs. Get copies from Paul Keim, Joe the Barber, Myrna & George Metz
- History of major floods, storms and snowfalls
- Get information on good trees to plant in the Township.

The next meeting of the Association will be on December 12th at 7:30. Any and all are invited to attend. Call Helen Mitchell, 724-456-7630, for further information.

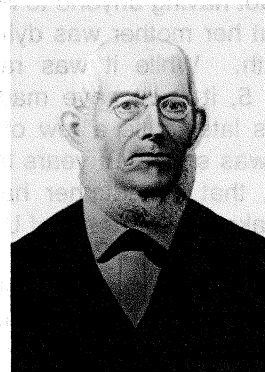
MORE MEMORIES OF OLD SHOUSETOWN

In the previous issue I related some of my Grandpa Harper's recollections of his life and times as a boy living in Shousetown, at the Point where Flaugherty Run empties into the Ohio.

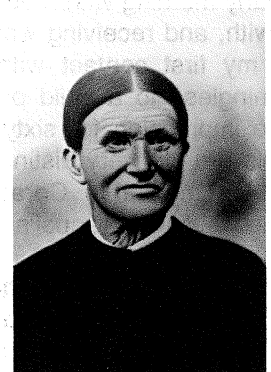
In this issue I have included Grandpa's recollections of his grandfather and grandmother. They were Johann Gottlieb and Johanna (Starz) Scharpf, the parents of Grandpa's mother, Sophia Frederick Scharpf. The only vestige of the Scharpf name in Crescent now is the name of Emma (*nee* Browning) Scharpf on the monument in the Shousetown Cemetery. She was the wife of William Scharpf, the middle child (of 5) of Johann and Johanna. and apparently she is the only Scharpf buried in Shousetown.

The Scharpf home, as best I can determine, was located approximately where the Crescent Municipal

Building is now situated, or perhaps where the parking lot in front is. According to Jack Owens, a great-grandson of Johann and Johanna, the house was originally a house-



Johann



Johanna

boat on the Ohio. During a flood the boat was moved to the location where it stood by Spring Run Road. Johann was a bootmaker and his shop was down the hill from the house, again as best I can determine, about where the firehouse is now located.

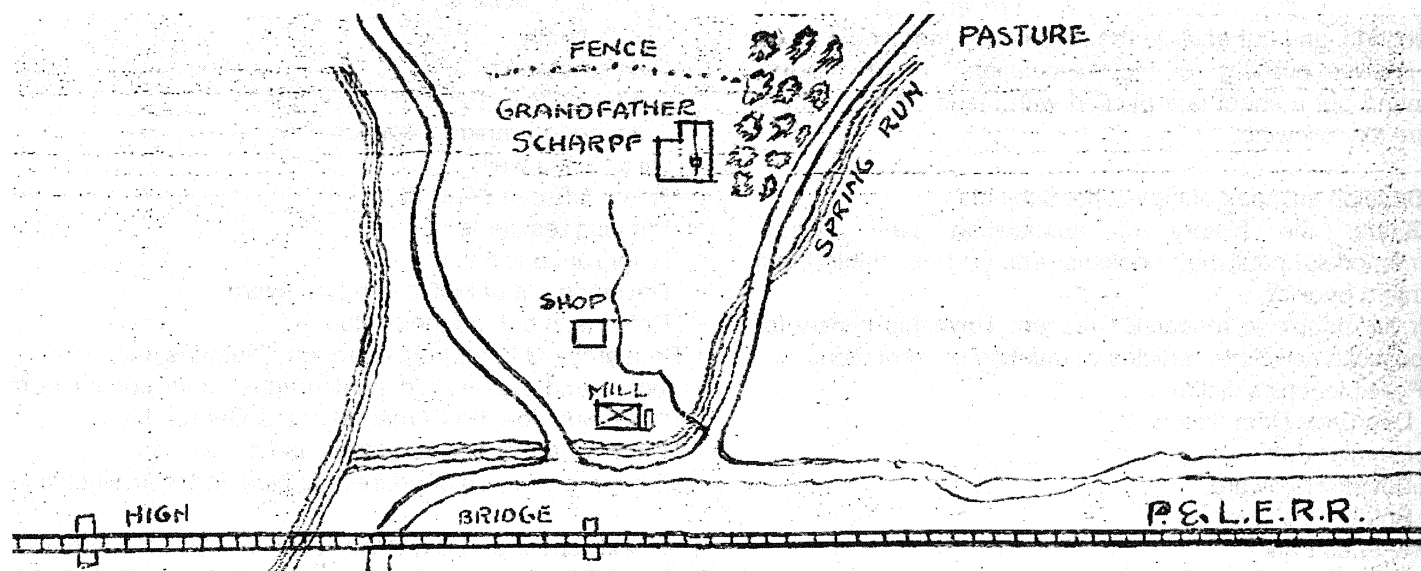
Grandpa, in his family history, wrote: "Born in Germany, the stories I always heard were to the effect that emigration to the United States was prompted by a desire to escape further military service and high taxes.

My first recollection of my mother's people was that they lived away out in the country. As a matter of fact our home was on the Point, where Flougherty Run empties into the Ohio River, and their home was in the first low hills back of the P. & L.E. in the fork of what is now Route 51 and Spring Run Road. This would be the equivalent of possibly six city blocks.

Grandfather was a shoemaker, or rather a bootmaker of no mean reputation. In those days a bootmaker was not primarily a repairman, but an artisan to whom came men of means for miles around, had measurements taken, and

in the course of time were the proud possessors of fine leather dress boots-of almost knee length, or heavier, more durable boots of heavy leather.

On Spring Run Road just before it took a sharp turn and pitched down a steep bank into Flougherty Run, was a flume to an old mill and the gate could be opened or closed from the foot bridge over the "Crick." From this point the path wound uphill for about half the distance to the house, and there on a level spot was grandfather's shop. From that point it was a steep grade to the gate giving entrance to the yard and house. For about seventy five feet directly back of the house the ground was only a gentle upward slope to a fencerow which in summer concealed three or four little graves with markers that chronicled some of the family tragedies. From that fence at the rear of the house it was really up, while on the other three sides it was down in stages varying from precipitous to just that degree that caused friends to kid grandfather about having to pick his tomatoes from a stepladder.



Part of a map of old Shousetown drawn from memory by Frank E. Harper.

There is no clear date that can be fixed, but in the latter years of my life in Shousetown, it was to a shop downtown that all we kids went on a Christmas morning, and there on the counter were ranged big red apples with a silver half dollar stuck in each one.

My most vivid recollection of grandmother Scharpf is of an early morning with mother. Not having anyone to leave me with, and receiving word that her mother was dying, I had my first contact with death. While it was rather meaningless to a child of 4 or 5, it must have made a grave impression for sixty years later quite a few of the details are still very distinct. It was some ten years later, after we moved to Coraopolis, that Grandfather had a stroke while in Coraopolis, was taken to the home of Uncle

Charlie (Scharpf), corner of State Street and Watson Street. and died a few days later.

Children--Frederic, Charlie, William, Herman L. and Sophia Frederica."

Postscript with the exception of Emma, most Scharpfs are buried in Coraopolis Cemetery. Johann, Johanna, Herman L. and Charles G. are all in the old section, very close to the road at the top of the hill. Sophia is buried with her husband, Joseph Harper. Frederick and his wife are buried in Sharon Presbyterian Cemetery. We have no idea where William is. The last record of him in Crescent Township was in the 1930 Census. If anyone has knowledge of his whereabouts, we'd like to know.

Editor's note - this newsletter is not intended to be solely reminiscences of my grandfather. I know there are folks out there who have stories told by their parents or grandparents about old Shousetown. We'd like to include these stories in future newsletters. If you have stories to share, please contact me, Don Harper, 4076 State Route 158, New Wilmington, PA 16142, or by telephone: 724-656-8359, or by e-mail : polychaete1@verizon.net Thanks.